

Chapter 9

As the sky gradually darkened, Yin Lingzhu and Ji Jingrong took Tiantian to the hospital for a checkup.

"You can rest assured. Tiantian's body is fine, and the doctor said you've been taking very good care of it."

Yin Lingzhu sat in the passenger seat, listening to Ji Jingrong speak to her.

She focused her gaze on Tiantian in the cat carrier.

Tiantian's eyes were half-closed, its two front paws crossed, chin resting on its front legs, looking listless.

Noticing its appearance, Yin Lingzhu felt uneasy in her heart, but she still responded to Ji Jingrong's words. "Mm, Tiantian's body is great."

"Let's hurry back." Yin Lingzhu placed the cat carrier on her lap.

Feeling Tiantian's weight, Yin Lingzhu couldn't feel at ease. She always felt something was going to happen tonight.

Ji Jingrong noticed Yin Lingzhu's nervousness. Now that the examination was over, although she didn't know what Yin Lingzhu was still worried about, she still offered comfort.

Listening to Ji Jingrong's words, the uneasiness in Yin Lingzhu's heart gradually disappeared.

At the intersection, the red light turned on.

Ji Jingrong's car speed slowly decreased. Just as the car was about to stop, another car suddenly appeared from another intersection.

The other car didn't slow down and crashed straight into them.

Ji Jingrong was the first to notice that car. Her car was currently in a low-speed state, and even though she jerked the steering wheel hard, there was still no way to avoid the collision.

The two cars collided, making a violent noise.

Fortunately, Ji Jingrong reacted quickly. The car's exterior was somewhat dented, but the interior was intact. She and Yin Lingzhu felt the impact, but weren't injured.

Just when the two were feeling relieved, an extremely mournful cat cry suddenly rang out.

When Yin Lingzhu saw the car coming toward her side, she had tightly protected the cat carrier in her arms.

Hearing the sound, she straightened up and saw Tiantian had shrunk to the innermost part of the carrier, the entire cat curled up.

Yin Lingzhu couldn't care about anything else now and opened the cat carrier.

The carrier she bought was very large - first, to prevent Tiantian from getting nervous in a cramped space, and second, to make it convenient for Tiantian to go in and out.

Therefore, Yin Lingzhu could easily put her hand inside.

She carefully placed her hand on Tiantian and felt the little cat trembling violently.

Yin Lingzhu's heart suddenly contracted. The sensation under her hand was too intense.

She didn't dare touch anymore and withdrew her hand.

"Don't worry. We're not far from the hospital. We can get there quickly now."

Seeing Yin Lingzhu's pale face, Ji Jingrong quickly turned the car around and rushed to the hospital.

The emergency light in the hospital room lit up.

Outside the room, Yin Lingzhu pressed her palms together, devoutly praying to heaven, hoping Tiantian would be safe.

After waiting for an unknown amount of time, the door opened.

The doctor came out and said "I'm sorry" to Yin Lingzhu.

Hearing these two words, Yin Lingzhu felt all the strength drain from her body and collapsed onto Ji Jingrong.

"Why?" Her mind went blank, not knowing how to release the emotions in her heart.

Ji Jingrong opened and closed her mouth, silently helping Yin Lingzhu to a chair, gently patting her back in wordless comfort.

Feeling the movement on her back, Yin Lingzhu's tears burst forth like a broken dam.

The quiet corridor echoed with Yin Lingzhu's broken sobs.

"Thank you." After Yin Lingzhu's emotions calmed down slightly, she raised her head and saw a large wet patch on Ji Jingrong's shoulder.

She knew those were her tears.

"When we get to the apartment, give me your clothes and I'll wash them for you." Yin Lingzhu said to Ji Jingrong.

Seeing Yin Lingzhu's emotions stabilize, Ji Jingrong also breathed a sigh of relief. She knew how important this cat was to Yin Lingzhu.

Regarding Yin Lingzhu's offer to wash her clothes, she nodded, then pulled out a photo from her gallery.

"Do you want her to compensate?" Ji Jingrong handed her phone to Yin Lingzhu.

This was a photo she had taken in her panic at the scene. Although it was somewhat blurry, the license plate was clear, and even the person in the car could be vaguely seen.

Yin Lingzhu naturally felt hate in her heart. She took the phone and carefully looked at the person in the photo.

After seeing clearly, an impossible person surfaced in her mind - someone she had been thinking about day and night.

Even though Yin Lingzhu's heart wanted to deny it, this silhouette had appeared countless times in her dreams. This person was Yan Si.

She tremblingly stuffed the phone back into Ji Jingrong's hands. "No need. She probably didn't do it on purpose."

Yin Lingzhu pulled her coat tighter, feeling a chill rising from the bottom of her heart.

She said to Ji Jingrong, "Let's go back. The hospital is a bit cold."

Yin Lingzhu returned home with Tiantian and the death certificate.

She put down Ji Jingrong's clothes, stroked Tiantian's stiff body, her mind filled with chaotic thoughts.

What Yan Si had given her was taken back by Yan Si in another form.

When Yan Si brought Tiantian back that day, she had been truly happy. She thought Yan Si had her in her heart.

Otherwise, why would she give her a kitten?

She often touched Tiantian's head and said, "I love your other owner so much."

After hearing this sentence, Tiantian would also affectionately nuzzle her face, making purring sounds.

When she was alone in the room thinking about Yan Si, Tiantian would also come over, lie beside her, and quietly accompany her.

Yin Lingzhu recalled these memories bit by bit, feeling another wave of sourness in her heart.

The apartment's lights were very bright, but Yin Lingzhu felt like she was in darkness, unable to find a single ray of light.

Gradually, she felt sharp pain coming from her nape, like needle pricks.

Yin Lingzhu remembered that the last time Yan Si came, she had experienced this situation the next day.

Yin Lingzhu had asked You Xiaoxiao about it.

You Xiaoxiao said this was a sequela of secondary differentiation¹ and warned her not to have excessive emotional fluctuations.

You Xiaoxiao had also prescribed medicine for Yin Lingzhu, telling her to take it on time, and if she experienced gland pain again, to come find her.

Yin Lingzhu covered her nape and let out an ambiguous laugh.

The next day, Yin Lingzhu went to the hospital.

Just as Yin Lingzhu was about to enter You Xiaoxiao's consultation room, she heard voices inside.

She lowered her hand from knocking and decided to wait until the conversation inside ended.

"You had a car accident yesterday." Yin Lingzhu hadn't walked far when she heard You Xiaoxiao's voice.

Yin Lingzhu stopped in her tracks.

"Mm, I was rushing to see Si Xin and wasn't paying attention." This was Yan Si's voice.

"Tsk tsk, how much did you compensate them?" This was You Xiaoxiao's voice.

"I didn't compensate." Yan Si paused. "I think I hit Yin Lingzhu, and her cat seems to have had problems."

You Xiaoxiao said with confusion, "Yin Lingzhu has a cat?"

"The cat she's raising - it couldn't be that one, could it? The one you originally wanted to give to Si Xin." You Xiaoxiao's tone rose.

"Right, Si Xin didn't want that cat. She disliked it for being a folded-ear²." Yan Si said.

Hearing this, Yin Lingzhu's mind could no longer function.

Si Xin? Originally meant for Si Xin? Disliked for being folded-ear?

Yin Lingzhu discovered she seemed to have lost the ability to think. She didn't want to consider what this meant - she was escaping.

Yan Si's casual few sentences had shattered all of Yin Lingzhu's joy and happiness.

"I can see that Yin Lingzhu quite likes you. The way you treat her..."

"You've been keeping Si Xin for over half a year, and except for marking, haven't you stopped going to Yin Lingzhu's place? I see you've been sleeping at Si Xin's house."

You Xiaoxiao was teasing Yan Si.

"Mm, I think Yin Lingzhu is dirty³. I don't like going there, and I don't really like Alphas." Yan Si's tone of disgust was very obvious.

Yin Lingzhu was struck as if by lightning. She couldn't even stand and softly collapsed into a chair, the pain in her nape intensifying.

But besides the physical pain, she felt her heart hurt even more severely.

No one had told her that loving someone who didn't like you back would make your heart hurt so much, like being cut by knives.

This suffocating feeling seemed like it would drown Yin Lingzhu in the next second.

Her nape seemed to hurt more and more, this pain seeming to spread throughout her entire body. Feeling her body's changes, Yin Lingzhu actually felt happy.

Maybe this is for the best. If I died here, Yan Si would still remember me.

With this thought, Yin Lingzhu was completely enveloped by pain and fainted.

When she woke up again, she was lying on a hospital bed with You Xiaoxiao standing in front of her.

"You're not suitable for major emotional fluctuations right now." Seeing her wake up, You Xiaoxiao organized the IV drip in her hands and spoke to her.

Yin Lingzhu looked around the entire hospital room. Besides You Xiaoxiao, there was no one else.

She had fainted at the door of You Xiaoxiao's consultation room, and Yan Si had been inside.

How could Yan Si not have noticed her?

Yin Lingzhu's lips were pale. She glanced at the needle on the back of her hand. "After this IV finishes, I want to go home."

The person on the hospital bed had no color in her face at all. The blood vessels on the back of her hand showed particularly clearly against her white skin, and her wrists were so slender they seemed like they could break at any moment.

Seeing her looking like she only had half a life left, You Xiaoxiao couldn't help but say, "You can't be discharged yet. Your physical condition is very dangerous."

Yin Lingzhu didn't listen to You Xiaoxiao's words and stubbornly insisted on going home.

Seeing her determined attitude, You Xiaoxiao said nothing more, gave her two packets of medicine, instructed her to take them on time, and left.

After finishing the IV, Yin Lingzhu immediately went home without staying.

Tomorrow was her birthday. Yan Si said she would come back.

Yan Si didn't like eating food bought from outside. She had to cook for her.

Maybe Yan Si would like the food she made.

On the way home, Yin Lingzhu bought a pile of groceries.

She worked from noon until evening, making a whole table full of food.

Yin Lingzhu sat at the table full of anticipation, waiting for midnight to arrive, waiting for Yan Si to arrive.

Time slowly reached midnight. When the numbers jumped from 59 to 00, a message popped up on her phone.

Yin Lingzhu hurriedly picked up her phone to look. It was birthday wishes from Ji Jingrong, densely packed words filling the entire screen.

Her gaze involuntarily drifted to the pinned chat. There was no movement in Yan Si's message box.

Perhaps Yan Si was too busy, or perhaps Yan Si went to bed very early.

Yin Lingzhu escaped again, making excuses for Yan Si.

She replied to Ji Jingrong's message. Just as she was about to put down her phone, Yan Si's message popped up.

[I'm not coming back. Happy birthday]

Yin Lingzhu typed out a long message, but in the end deleted it and sent [Thank you].

The room was frighteningly quiet. Usually there would be Tiantian's meowing, but now there was nothing.

Yin Lingzhu sat in the chair, facing a large table of food all alone, and suddenly felt useless.

Even though she had worked so hard to learn, she still didn't know how to win Yan Si's heart.

No tutorial told her what to do when you'd been married for a year but only met ten times.

Yin Lingzhu stuck candles in the cake. The flames gradually descended and extinguished when they touched the cream.

Yin Lingzhu took out her phone and sent Ji Jingrong a message.

[Will you accompany me for surgery?]

Footnotes: ¹ Secondary differentiation (二次分化) - In Omegaverse, this refers to when someone's initial biological designation (Alpha, Beta, Omega) changes later in life, often causing physical and emotional complications.

² Folded-ear (折耳) - Refers to Scottish Fold cats, which are known for their distinctive folded ears but often have serious genetic health problems related to cartilage defects.

³ Dirty (脏) - This is a particularly cruel insult in this context, as it not only refers to physical cleanliness but also implies moral or sexual impurity, striking at Yin Lingzhu's deepest insecurities.